for their liaison work in foreign countries and to host foreign delegations in China.

Others like the Chinese Institute for International Studies (CIIS) which is related to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the Chinese Institutes for Contemporary International Relations (CICIR), which is affiliated to the Ministry of State Security, the Chinese Academy of Social Sciences (CASS), which is affiliated to the State Council, or the Chinese Institute for International Strategic Studies, which is affiliated to the PLA, are research and information providers which churn out material on issues that are the subject of bilateral and multilateral negotiation. According to one research paper, delegation visits by Chinese think-tanks to India in the aftermath of India's nuclear tests were instrumental in providing Chinese policymakers with insights into New Delhi's intentions and threat perceptions. [21]

The Chinese have imbued their think-tanks with an air of mystery. Most are staffed by retired or serving personnel of the mother institution, and they are often the only point of access for foreign embassies or governments to learn about Chinese thinking. Over time, they have come to be regarded as a go-to source to understand any matter due to the scarcity of public information on how decisions are made, and also because of a lack of direct access to the decision makers in China. It is assumed that the think-tanks and many of the more senior academics have informal access to the 'leadership'. In turn, in world capitals, the Chinese think-tank community is given a greater level of access by foreign governments than is the case with think-tank communities from elsewhere, which places them in the unique position of both influencing their foreign interlocutor and of gaining first-hand insight into the thought processes of the foreign government. These inputs can prove enormously helpful to Chinese negotiators. The free and open information system of democracies also permits Chinese think-